

Session 23: Identifying Repeated Words

Key Takeaways

- Repeated words, phrases, and parallel themes connect individual stories across the Hebrew Bible and the New Testament.
- Biblical authors use repetition of lead words to create patterns that guide the reader's focus and create expectations for the reader.
- A "lead word" is a word that repeats significantly in a text or group of texts. The biblical authors use variations of Hebrew word roots to create wordplay and repetition.

Identifying Repeated Words (Coordination)

As the biblical authors collected and arranged the narratives and poems, they also created coordinating connections by linking units together through repeated words and themes. The biblical authors were masters of this technique. The most fundamental tools in their repertoire were patterned repetition and analogy, which they accomplished using the simplest of means: strategic repetition of key words.

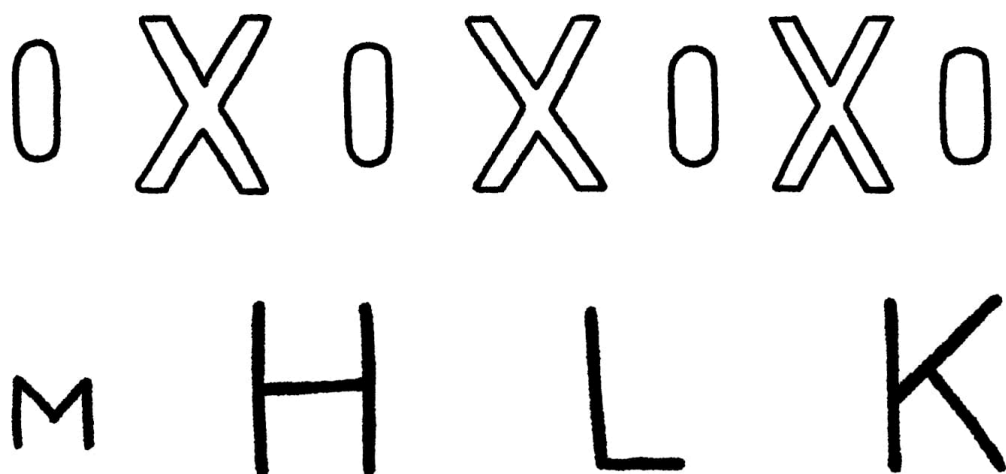
Dense Repetition

Dense repetition of a word or word family can signal a core theme of a literary unit. These are known as lead words.

"A lead-word (German: *leitwort*) is a word or word-root that repeats significantly in a text or group of texts, and by following these repetitions, one is able to decipher or grasp a meaning of the text ... The repetition may not be of the same exact word, but of the word-root ... which intensifies the dynamic action of the repetition ... if you imagine the entire text stretched out before you, you can sense waves moving back and forth between key words, matching the rhythm of the text ... it is one of the most powerful means of conveying meaning."

Buber, Martin (2012). [*Schriften zur Bibel*](#). Gütersloher Verlagshaus. 1131.

Hebrew is based on a system of three-consonant root words. This illustration helps show how related words, visually and aurally obvious in the original Hebrew, would be used to create thematic groupings by repetition.



Genesis 1 Literary Units. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

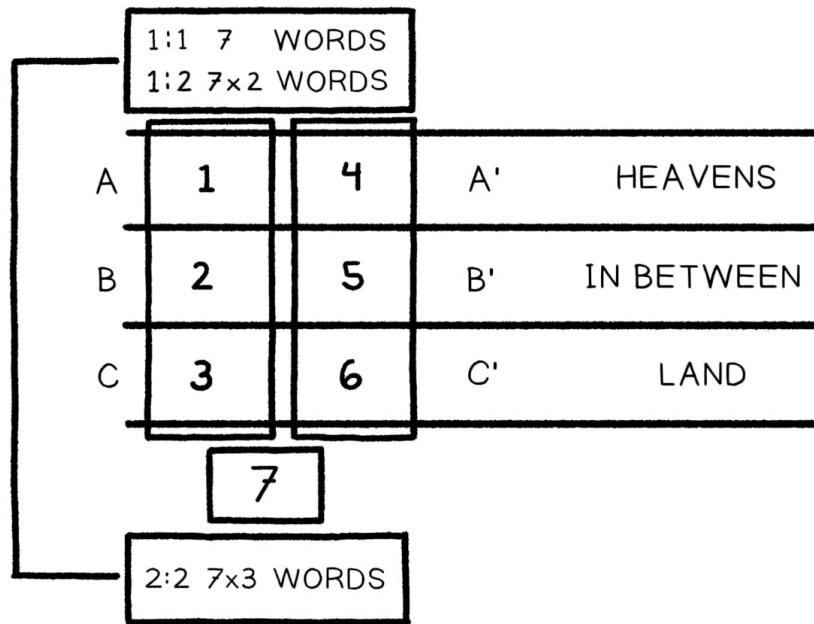
Repetition of “Good” in Genesis 1

- Genesis 1:4: “And God saw that the light was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב).”
- Genesis 1:10: “And God saw that [the dry land] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב).”
- Genesis 1:12: “And God saw that [the vegetation] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב).”
- Genesis 1:18: “And God saw that [the lights] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב).”
- Genesis 1:21: “And God saw that [the sea life] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב).”
- Genesis 1:25: “And God saw that [the land life] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב).”
- Genesis 1:31: “And God saw all that he had made, and look, it was very good (וִירָא ... וְהָנָה טוֹב מְאֹד).”

This phrase is like a drumbeat during days one through six, and it sets the reader’s expectation so that the different wording of the seventh repetition of “very good” stands out and feels climactic.

In terms of God’s character portrait, this repetition makes a clear claim: God is the provider and evaluator of what is truly good. In Genesis 1, “good” defines the ordered environments that make life possible (days one through three), and it defines the abundant creatures that fill the skies and the land (days four through six).

DAYS OF CREATION



Genesis 1 Literary Units. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Repetition of “Bless” in Genesis 12:1-3

Genesis 12:1-3 NASB

¹ Now the LORD said to Abram,
 “Go forth from your country,
 and from your relatives
 and from your father’s house,
 to the land which I will show you;
² and I will make you a great nation,
 and I will **ble**ss you,
 and make your name great;
 and so you shall be a **ble**ssing;
³ and I will bless those who **ble**ss you,
 and the one who curses you I will curse.
 And in you all the families of the earth will be **ble**ssed.”

Reflection Question

What stands out to you about how repetition or structure works in Genesis 1?